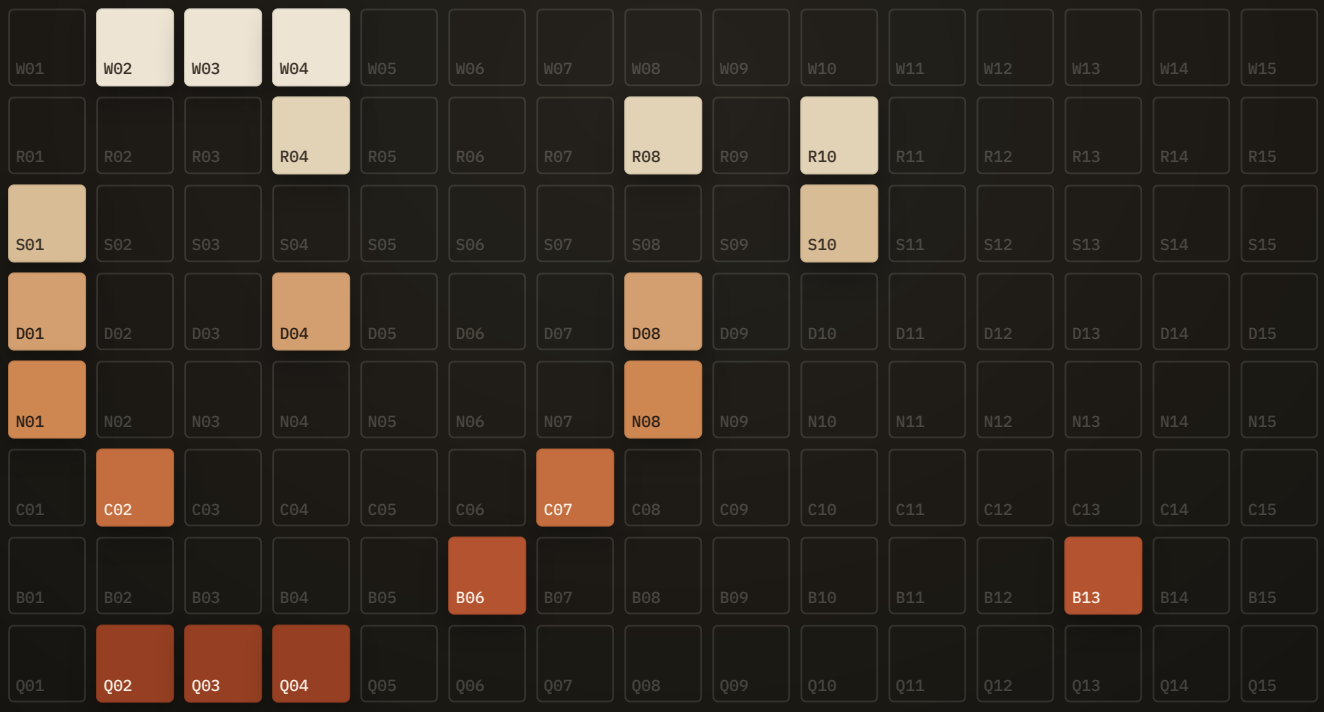
FREE SAMPLER · FROM CLAUDE WITHOUT GUESSWORK

The 20-Prompt Starter

Twenty copy-ready prompts for real work, hand-picked from the 120-Prompt Playbook



LIT TILES ARE IN THIS STARTER · THE FULL 120 COME WITH THE BOOK

20 PROMPTS · 8 CATEGORIES · FREE TO SHARE

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BEFORE YOU START

How to use this starter

Twenty prompts from *Claude Without Guesswork*, chosen because they help with work almost everyone does: hard emails, meetings, research, documents, spreadsheets, content, and decisions. Each one is a starting point you adapt, not a magic formula.

01

Find the job, not the prompt

Use the list on the next page. Titles describe the task: “The firm follow-up”, “Compare two versions”.

02

Fill every slot

Anything in `[brackets]` is yours to supply. An empty slot gets you a guess back, and guessing is exactly what these prompts are built to avoid.

03

Match the checks to the stakes

If a wrong answer would cost money or reputation, check the output before you use it. The book’s Chapter 9 shows how to test a prompt you will rely on.

04

Keep the ones that work twice

When a prompt works on two real tasks, save it with your own slots filled in. That is the start of a personal prompt library.

READING A CARD

1. **ID, title, and chapter.** The chapter of the book where the technique is taught.
2. **Use when.** The situation the prompt is built for.
3. **The prompt.** Copy it as written, then replace the slots. Tags such as `<old>` mark where pasted material goes.
4. **Why it works.** The one design choice that makes the difference, so you can keep it when you adapt the prompt.

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Not professional advice. Prompts that touch documents, money, or decisions help you prepare and organise your thinking. They are no substitute for a qualified professional. Always check outputs before you rely on them.

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NOT IN THIS STARTER

The full *120-Prompt Playbook* has 100 more, including:

W06 Apology that owns it
W12 Negotiation counter
R09 Project status RAG
R12 SOP from a walkthrough
S03 Citation audit
S11 What changed recently
D05 Photo transcription
D12 Glossary extraction
N02 Clean with a log
N06 Reconcile two files
N10 Budget vs actual
C04 Short-video script table
C10 Headline options
B02 Proposal with edges
B12 Supplier comparison
Q06 Test set builder
Q07 Calibrated grader
Q13 Memory audit

01

CATEGORY 1 OF 8 · 3 OF 15 IN THIS STARTER

Writing and email

Replies, refusals, follow-ups, apologies, and hard messages that take a clear position and still keep the relationship.

W01 Reply with a stance
W02 Say no, keep the relationship
W03 The firm follow-up
W04 Bad news, first sentence
W05 Edit, don't comment
W06 Apology that owns it
W07 Ask for something
W08 Cold outreach, honest
W09 Tone shift
W10 Shorten by half
W11 Thank-you that's specific
W12 Negotiation counter
W13 Difficult message rehearsal
W14 Language pack
W15 Inbox triage

Highlighted prompts are in this starter. The greyed ones are in the full 120-Prompt Playbook, which comes with the book.

W02 Say no, keep the relationship

Taught in Ch. 11

USE WHEN Declining a request, client, or invitation.

```
I need to decline [request] from [who; relationship].
Give one honest reason: [reason]. Offer [alternative, or "no alternative"].
Don't leave the door open to renegotiation. Warm, brief, under 100 words.
```

WHY IT WORKS Explicit reason, alternative, and a closed door stop the reply from wobbling.

W03 The firm follow-up

Taught in Ch. 11

USE WHEN Chasing a reply, payment, or delivery.

```
This is my [second/third] follow-up about [topic].
Facts: [reference numbers, dates, amounts].
Write a short follow-up that states exactly what I need, from whom, by when, and what happens next if there's no reply.
Firm and courteous; no guilt-tripping; under 90 words.
```

WHY IT WORKS Facts plus one dated ask make a follow-up easy to answer.

W04 Bad news, first sentence

Taught in Ch. 11

USE WHEN Delays, price rises, mistakes.

```
I have to tell [audience] that [the news].
Structure: the news in the first sentence; what it means for them; what we're doing about it; what they can do.
No excuses, no blame. Under [N] words.
```

WHY IT WORKS Leading with the news respects the reader; the structure prevents burying it.

02

CATEGORY 2 OF 8 · 3 OF 15 IN THIS STARTER

Reports, meetings, and plans

Outlines, minutes, agendas, decision memos, status reports, and plans built around real constraints.

R01 Report outline first
R02 Minutes with honest gaps
R03 Plan within real constraints
R04 Pre-mortem
R05 Weekly update from a tracker
R06 Agenda that decides
R07 Meeting prep from calendar
R08 Decision memo
R09 Project status RAG
R10 Turn notes into tasks
R11 Quarterly review
R12 SOP from a walkthrough
R13 Capacity check
R14 Retrospective
R15 One-slide summary

Highlighted prompts are in this starter. The greyed ones are in the full 120-Prompt Playbook, which comes with the book.

R04 Pre-mortem

Taught in Ch. 11

USE WHEN Before committing to any plan.

```
It's [date after deadline] and [plan] failed.
Write the five most likely reasons, based on this plan and its constraints, most likely first.
For each: one early warning sign and one change that would reduce the risk.
```

WHY IT WORKS Imagining a specific failure surfaces risks a vague "what could go wrong?" misses.

R08 Decision memo

Taught in Ch. 17

USE WHEN Recording a decision.

```
Write a decision memo: decision; date; options considered; why this one; what would make us
revisit it; owner. Under 250 words. Use only facts from [notes].
```

WHY IT WORKS A record you'll be glad of later.

R10 Turn notes into tasks

Taught in Ch. 11

USE WHEN After brainstorming.

```
From these notes, list concrete tasks: verb first, owner if named, due date if stated, else
"owner?"/"date?". Group by project. [notes]
```

WHY IT WORKS Notes become action without invented owners.

03

CATEGORY 3 OF 8 · 2 OF 15 IN THIS STARTER

Research and sources

Research briefs, citation audits, competitor scans, and source checks where every claim can be traced.

S01 A research brief
S02 Legitimate way out
S03 Citation audit
S04 Decision brief before research
S05 Red-team a report
S06 Evidence ladder rating
S07 Compare definitions
S08 Interview guide
S09 Summarize calls with IDs
S10 Competitor scan
S11 What changed recently
S12 Explain a study
S13 Source pack for a claim
S14 Research with my data
S15 Learning plan

Highlighted prompts are in this starter. The greyed ones are in the full 120-Prompt Playbook, which comes with the book.

S01 A research brief

Taught in Ch. 13

USE WHEN Before any web search or Research run.

```
Research question: [question].
Place: [where]; time: [period]; sources: prefer [official statistics, company pages, trade bodies]; label vendor blogs as weak.
Exclude: [what's out of scope].
Output: five-bullet summary, then a table: claim, source, date, source type, confidence.
End with what you couldn't find.
```

WHY IT WORKS The six edges (topic, place, time, sources, exclusions, output) make a question answerable.

S10 Competitor scan

Taught in Ch. 13

USE WHEN Market overview.

```
Search the web for [N] competitors in [market, place]. For each: offer, price (with date and source), positioning in their own words, and one gap. Mark anything you couldn't verify.
```

WHY IT WORKS Dated, sourced competitor facts.

04

CATEGORY 4 OF 8 · 3 OF 15 IN THIS STARTER

Documents and files

Quoting, extracting, comparing, and summarising PDFs, scans, photos, and forms without losing what matters.

D01 Quote, then answer
D02 Coverage test
D03 Table extraction with pages
D04 Compare two versions
D05 Photo transcription
D06 Clause finder
D07 Document identity tags
D08 Plain-language summary
D09 Form filler draft
D10 Chart reading
D11 Alt text
D12 Glossary extraction
D13 Translation brief
D14 Consistency check
D15 Redaction plan

Highlighted prompts are in this starter. The greyed ones are in the full 120-Prompt Playbook, which comes with the book.

D01 Quote, then answer

Taught in Ch. 8

USE WHEN Questions about long documents.

```
First, extract every passage about [topic] from the documents, word for word, each in a <quote>
tag with document number and clause or page.
If none, write "No relevant passage."
Then, in <answer>, answer using only those quotes, citing the quote number after each sentence.
Don't use general knowledge of [field].
```

WHY IT WORKS Every sentence is tied to text you can check; a missing quote means missing information.

D04 Compare two versions

Taught in Ch. 15

USE WHEN Contracts, price lists, policies that changed.

```
Compare <old> and <new> (attached). List every difference as: item, old wording or value, new
wording or value, page in each.
Then mark which differences cost us money or reduce our options.
If they're identical in a section, say so; don't summarize sections.
```

WHY IT WORKS A complete diff, then a judgment, in that order.

D08 Plain-language summary

Taught in Ch. 15

USE WHEN Dense documents.

```
Summarize [document] in plain language for [reader]: what it's for, what it requires of them,
deadlines, and penalties. Quote the clause behind each point.
```

WHY IT WORKS Plain words with receipts.

05

CATEGORY 5 OF 8 · 2 OF 15 IN THIS STARTER

Data and numbers

Profiling, cleaning, reconciling, and modelling spreadsheets, with summaries that tie back to the numbers.

N01 Profile before cleaning
N02 Clean with a log
N03 Questions, then cuts
N04 What-if model with formulas
N05 Executive summary that ties out
N06 Reconcile two files
N07 Pivot by question
N08 Formula explainer
N09 Chart with one message
N10 Budget vs actual
N11 Price-volume check
N12 Data dictionary
N13 Cohort view
N14 Anomaly scan
N15 Script request

Highlighted prompts are in this starter. The greyed ones are in the full 120-Prompt Playbook, which comes with the book.

N01 Profile before cleaning

Taught in Ch. 16

USE WHEN Any new spreadsheet or export.

```
Profile the attached [file] using code. Don't change anything.
Report: rows and columns; each column's type and blanks; distinct values for text columns with under 30 values; anything inconsistent (spellings, dates, numbers as text, duplicates, negatives).
For each issue: row count, three examples, and whether it's definitely an error or might be legitimate.
```

WHY IT WORKS "Might be legitimate" protects refunds and returns from being "cleaned" away.

N08 Formula explainer

Taught in Ch. 16

USE WHEN Inherited spreadsheets.

```
Explain what each formula in [sheet/range] does, in plain words, and flag any hard-coded numbers, broken references, or inconsistent formulas across rows.
```

WHY IT WORKS Finds the fragile cells.

06

CATEGORY 6 OF 8 · 2 OF 15 IN THIS STARTER

Content and marketing

Strategy, voice, scripts, carousels, newsletters, and claims checks for content you can publish with confidence.

C01 Strategy, interview first
C02 Voice guide from samples
C03 Three examples, not adjectives
C04 Short-video script table
C05 Claims check
C06 Idea bank from questions
C07 Repurpose, facts locked
C08 Carousel
C09 Newsletter section
C10 Headline options
C11 Content review gate
C12 Performance review
C13 Campaign brief
C14 Product page rewrite
C15 Media kit numbers

Highlighted prompts are in this starter. The greyed ones are in the full 120-Prompt Playbook, which comes with the book.

C02 Voice guide from samples

Taught in Ch. 23

USE WHEN Capturing how you or your brand sounds.

```
Analyze the attached [N] pieces of my content. Write a voice guide:
five traits, each with a quoting example; a "we write / we don't write" pair per trait; words I
use and words I never use; sentence length and emoji habits with counts.
Use only what's in the samples; leave out traits seen in just one.
```

WHY IT WORKS Evidence and contrast beat adjectives.

C07 Repurpose, facts locked

Taught in Ch. 23

USE WHEN One idea, many formats.

```
Adapt the approved [master] into [formats]. Keep every fact identical; adapt length, structure,
and opening. List any place you had to add a fact.
```

WHY IT WORKS Form changes; facts don't.

07

CATEGORY 7 OF 8 · 2 OF 15 IN THIS STARTER

Business and decisions

Proposals, options tables, unit economics, supplier comparisons, and the assumptions behind every decision.

B01 Objection map
B02 Proposal with edges
B03 Attack the model
B04 Feedback on behavior
B05 Customer reply library
B06 Options table
B07 Assumption register
B08 Investor update
B09 Structured interview kit
B10 Change request reply
B11 Policy gap finder
B12 Supplier comparison
B13 Unit economics
B14 Workflow card
B15 Handover test

Highlighted prompts are in this starter. The greyed ones are in the full 120-Prompt Playbook, which comes with the book.

B06 Options table

Taught in Ch. 14

USE WHEN Any decision.

```
For [decision], list options in a table: cost, time, risk, reversibility, what we'd have to believe. Then which option wins under each of two scenarios: [A] and [B]. Don't pick one overall.
```

WHY IT WORKS Shows trade-offs without hiding the call.

B13 Unit economics

Taught in Ch. 16

USE WHEN Pricing and channels.

```
Using code: for each [product/channel], revenue, cost, gross margin %, and share of gross profit. Then where a 5% price change would matter most.
```

WHY IT WORKS Where profit actually comes from.

08

CATEGORY 8 OF 8 · 3 OF 15 IN THIS STARTER

Quality, safety, and prompting

Full specs, review criteria, test sets, injection guards, and the habits that keep results reliable.

Q01 ARROWS full spec
Q02 Ask me first
Q03 Review against criteria
Q04 Handoff summary
Q05 Untrusted content guard
Q06 Test set builder
Q07 Calibrated grader
Q08 Conflict finder
Q09 Prompt critique
Q10 Explain the why
Q11 Risk rating
Q12 Prepare for a professional
Q13 Memory audit
Q14 Project briefing check
Q15 Scheduled task spec

Highlighted prompts are in this starter. The greyed ones are in the full 120-Prompt Playbook, which comes with the book.

Q02 Ask me first

Taught in Ch. 5

USE WHEN Ambiguous tasks.

```
Before you start, ask me up to three questions, but only ones whose answers would change the result.
If nothing is worth asking, just begin.
```

WHY IT WORKS Gets the missing context without a pointless interview.

Q03 Review against criteria

Taught in Ch. 7

USE WHEN Before using any important output.

```
Check [output] against these criteria: [numbered, checkable criteria].
Show a table of items that fail any criterion, with the criterion and why.
Don't change anything until I've seen the table.
```

WHY IT WORKS Separates diagnosis from treatment.

Q04 Handoff summary

Taught in Ch. 7

USE WHEN Moving work to a new chat.

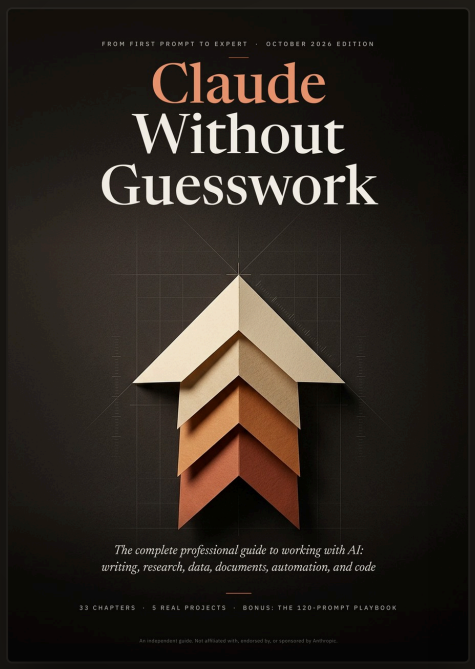
```
I'll continue in a new chat. Write a handoff summary under 200 words: end goal; decisions I made, with reasons; key figures and facts; what's done and what's left, in order; constraints I set. Write it so someone who never saw this chat could continue.
```

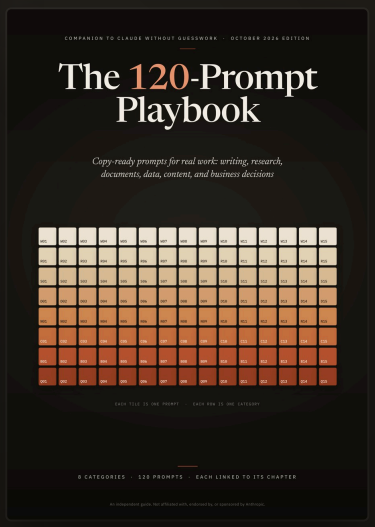
WHY IT WORKS Carries context without a bloated conversation.

WHERE THESE PROMPTS COME FROM

A prompt helps once. The method lasts.

These 20 prompts come from *Claude Without Guesswork*. The book teaches why they work, so you can write the next one yourself and know when to trust the answer.





- **33 chapters, 279 pages:** from your first prompt to research, documents, spreadsheets, content, coding, Claude Code, connectors, and automation.
- **5 capstone projects** and practice files, so you learn on real work, not toy examples.
- **The full 120-Prompt Playbook** comes with it: all eight categories, 15 prompts each.
- **Checked, not guessed:** every fact that changes over time carries a note naming its official source and the date it was checked.

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